

Bluff Your Way Through

INFLATING POPULARITY ONLINE is a new fad that seems to have caught the fancy of some social networking regulars. With sites like MySpace, friendster, Orkut, and Facebook signing up new members by the minute—and hordes of socially active (socially starved in the real world?) people signing up—a strange new competition has been initiated within that community. It is the race to be famous and project an image of being a popular and affable person: one whose roster of personal-page friends is long (and contains good-looking ones!) and with the “friends” endorsing not just their friendship but even dropping in a few positive comments. This weird “popularity contest” has spawned one of the most bizarre sites I’ve come across: fakeyourspace.com.

With some help from the site, you can actually fake your personal profile page at any of the above sites and hire good-looking (almost model-like) friends for only a dollar a month. The service doesn’t end there: apart from serving up model-esque friends, FakeYourSpace also enables you to create customised messages for the comments list on your profile pages.

This essentially means that if you’ve dreamt of having “hot” friends whom you could not befriend, here’s a chance to grab them for just 45 rupees. And for us Indians, it gets even better. We can now rent *phirang* friends (mostly American) to pump up our reputations! Obviously, the site ensures that the friends you rent are very normal in their actions and personalities, and their comments don’t sound fake—ensuring you’re never caught.

According to Brent Walker, the founder of the site based in San Diego, the purpose behind the site was “to turn cyberlosers into social-networking magnets.”

Walker’s inspiration is a consequence of an emerging trend that Bruce Schneier, a security expert and well-known tech blogger describes as “the social network reputation hack.”

Another site that feeds into this new development is popularitydialer.com. It arranges for fake phone calls that make you look popular while you’re



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“There is a race to be famous and project an image of being a popular and affable person online”

at a social do or amongst people you want to impress with your “social status.”

To my simple understanding, the sole reason for the existence of all the new social networking sites was to help one acquire new and interesting friends, find a few more like-minded ones, and facilitate networking in existing relationships. However these sites also gave a chance to real-world social “losers” to build, forge, and seek new relationships if they weren’t successful at it in their childhood, workplace, or even in their own family.

With the successful launch of sites like FakeYourSpace and popularitydialer.com, the concept has been taken too far.

Shortcomings of human nature that affected real-world relationships had found an answer online. Innocent enough. Not any more.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'D. Ajwani'.

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